that Jewish sovereignty over the holy sites would make Zionism unpalatable to Christians, so he proposed making it an extra-territorial entity.

Attitudes began to change around 1918, under the leadership of Chaim Weizmann, the chairman of the Zionist Commission for Palestine. He felt that Jewish control of the Western Wall would be a powerful symbol. “We feel that at the present time, when the Jewry are looking forward to a revival of its national life, would be all times the most fitting for the carrying out of this project,” Weizmann wrote in 1918. The city gained further importance after the riots of 1929, which were centered in Jerusalem. Yet even after the young state of Israel declared Jerusalem its capital in 1949, there was still little popular demand for a campaign to unite the city, as Bernard Wasserstein wrote in his 2001 history. “Few political voices in Israel and none in the government before June 1967 called for an irredentist policy towards east Jerusalem. The country thus found itself politically, diplomatically and psychologically unprepared when, quite unexpectedly, after nineteen years of division, Jerusalem was, almost overnight, reunited under Israeli rule.”[1]

The reunification came in 1967, during the Six-Day War. The fighting was costly: three dozen Israeli soldiers were killed just to seize Ammunition Hill, a fortified Jordanian position near the border. By 7 June, though, two days into the war, the Israeli army had largely surrounded the walled Old City. A small detachment of soldiers fought their way through the winding alleys until they reached the Western Wall, the sole remaining edifice of the Biblical temple. Atop it sits the Temple Mount, the onetime site of the Holy of Holies, the inner sanctuary where Jews believe God dwelt. Their victory was recorded in the driest of military prose: the daily after-action log blandly notes *“har habayt b’yadeinu”*—“The Temple Mount is in our hands.” Shlomo Goren, the army’s chief rabbi, quickly made his way to the site, where he blew a *shofar* (ram’s horn) and held the first Jewish prayers in nearly two decades.

But atop the plateau is also Al-Aqsa mosque, Islam’s third-holiest, and the Dome of the Rock, where Muslims believe Mohammed made his “night journey”, ascending to heaven on a winged horse. Elsewhere in the Old City, and radiating outward in neighborhoods like Silwan and Sheikh Jarrah, there were Palestinians. All of this was in Israel’s hands, too.